

A simple guide

The Guidance Flow

Helping a child begin reading

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Proverbs 22:6

***Train up a child in the way he should go,
And when he is old he will not depart
from it.***

*You're not just teaching reading—you're
setting the path.*

Important

This guide is designed to be used with the **Sam & Dot reading system**.

The method in this book works best with:

- controlled vocabulary
- simple sentence structure
- repeated word patterns

Using this method with other books may not produce the same results.

*This method is built to match the structure of the **Sam and Dot books**.*

The Guidance Flow

(Guide = Adult/Facilitator)

The Guidance Flow shows how the Guide learns to
guide.

Sit with your child.

Keep it calm.

Point to each word.

Read it smoothly.

Do not stop.

Turn the page.

Repeat.

How to Begin Reading Together

The goal

The goal is **not** to make the child sound out words.

The goal is to help the child:

- hear the words
- see the words
- connect the printed word to what is being said
- grow familiar enough to begin recognizing the words naturally

This begins with **modeling**, not testing.

1. What the Guide should understand first

At the beginning:

- the Guide reads
- the child looks
- the Guide points to each word
- the child gradually begins to recognize the repeated words

Do **not** start by teaching:

- letter names
- letter sounds
- sounding out
- blending
- spelling

At first, the child is learning:

- “This word says Sam”
- “This word says Dot”
- “This word says See”

That is enough.

2. What should a first reading session look like

Keep the first session very simple.

Step 1: Sit together

Have the child sit where they can clearly see the page.

Keep it relaxed.

Do not announce:

- “Today we are learning to read.”

Instead say something simple like:

- “Let’s look at this book.”
- “Let’s read together.”
- “Look, here’s Sam.”

Step 2: Open the book and read smoothly

Point to each word as you say it.

Example:

Point to **See** and say “See”

Point to **Sam** and say “Sam”

Then say the line smoothly:

“See Sam.”

Do not stop and explain.

Do not break the word apart.

Do not go backward.

Just move left to right and continue.

Step 3: Turn the page and repeat

Do the same on every page.

For example:

- point to each word
- say the sentence smoothly
- turn the page
- keep going

The Guide is demonstrating what reading looks like.

3. What the Guide Should NOT do

A new Guide will often accidentally turn this into a quiz. Avoid that.

Do not ask:

- “What letter is this?”
- “What sound does S make?”
- “Can you sound it out?”
- “What does this spell?”
- “Say the sounds.”

Do not say:

- “No, that’s wrong.”
- “Try again.”
- “You know this.”
- “Come on, read it.”

Do not over-explain.

Do not force performance.

The child should feel:

- safe
- interested
- successful
- calm

4. What the Guide SHOULD do instead

The Guide should:

- read warmly
- point lightly to each word
- keep the pace smooth
- allow repetition
- let the child join naturally when ready

That is the method.

5. What happens over repeated readings

This is important for a Guide to understand:

If the same book is read over and over, that is **not a problem**.

That is the learning.

The repetition helps the child connect:

- the spoken word
- the printed word
- the picture
- the sentence pattern

So if the child hears and sees:

See Sam

See Sam

See Sam

then eventually the child looks at **Sam** and knows:

that says Sam

That is the beginning of reading.

6. What the Guide should expect over time

Stage 1: The child watches

At first the child may just listen and look.

That is fine.

Stage 2: The child anticipates

After repeated readings, the child may start saying:

- “Sam”
- “Dot”
- “ball”

That is also fine.

Stage 3: The child joins in

The child may start filling in the last word of a line.

Example:

Guide: “See...”

Child: “Sam”

That is a good sign.

Stage 4: The child recognizes whole lines

Eventually the child may say:

- “See Sam”
- “See Dot”

This comes from familiarity and recognition.

7. How long each session should be

Keep sessions short.

A good beginner session is:

- 3 to 5 minutes
- 1 book
- possibly read more than once

Stop while the child is still comfortable.

Do not drag it out.

Short, calm repetition is better than one long session.

8. How many times should the same book be read

As many times as needed.

A Guide may worry:

- “Are we doing the same book too much?”

For this stage, repetition is the point.

It is normal to read the same book:

- several times in one day
- several days in a row
- until the child clearly knows it well

Do not rush to the next book just to feel progress.

Familiarity builds confidence.

9. How the Guide should point to the words

Keep the finger movement simple.

- point to the first word as you say it
- move to the second word as you say it
- continue left to right

Do not tap wildly.

Do not wave around the page.

Do not point to pictures while reading the sentence.

The finger should quietly show:

this is the word I am saying

10. When to pause for the child

Only after the child has heard the book enough times.

A gentle pause is okay.

Example:

Guide points and says: “See...”

pause briefly

if the child says “Sam,” wonderful

if not, Guide simply says “Sam” and keeps going

The pause should feel light, not like a test.

11. What the Guide should say before reading

Keep the intro simple.

Good examples:

- “Let’s read this.”
- “Look, this is Sam.”
- “Here is Dot.”
- “Let’s see what happens.”

Do not start with:

- “Now say the sounds.”
- “Now we are going to decode.”
- “Now tell me the letters.”

12. What the Guide should say during reading

Use a calm, natural voice.

Example:

- “See Sam.”
- “See Dot.”
- “See the ball.”

That is enough.

You are modeling reading, not lecturing.

13. What the Guide should say after reading

Keep it warm and simple.

Examples:

- “You did a great job looking.”
- “You listened so well.”
- “You found Sam.”
- “You knew Dot.”

Praise engagement and recognition, not performance pressure.

14. What if the child is not saying anything yet

That is fine.

A child does not need to speak right away for learning to happen.

If the child is:

- looking
- listening
- staying engaged
- watching the pointing

then learning is happening.

Do not panic just because the child is quiet.

15. What if the child memorizes the book

That is not failure.

At this stage, memorized pattern reading is part of the path.

The child is learning:

- book structure
- word pattern
- repeated vocabulary
- visual recognition

Memorization plus print awareness helps create early reading behavior.

16. What if the child points to pictures instead of words

That is normal early on.

The Guide should gently guide back to the words by continuing to point to the print while reading.

No correction lecture is needed.

Just keep modeling:

- finger on word
- voice says word

Over time the child notices the connection.

17. When not to introduce decoding yet

Do **not** introduce sounding out if the child is still in the early recognition stage.

If the child is just beginning to:

- know Sam
- know Dot
- know See
- join in on repeated lines

then stay there.

Do not interrupt that with:

- “S says /s/”
- “A says /a/”
- “Blend it”

Let recognition stabilize first.

18. What success looks like at this stage

Success is not:

- naming letters
- sounding out words
- formal decoding

Success looks like:

- the child enjoys the book
- the child watches the pointing
- the child begins recognizing repeated words
- the child joins in on familiar lines
- the child grows confident

That is real progress.

19. A sample first session script for a Guide

Here is a simple model.

Before opening the book

“Let’s look at this book together.”

Page 1

Point to each word:

“See Sam.”

Page 2

Point to each word:

“See Dot.”

Page 3

Point to each word:

“See the ball.”

Continue

Read each page the same way:

- point
- say it smoothly
- turn page

After the book

“That was good.”

“You saw Sam.”

“Let’s read it again later.”

That is enough.

The Rule

The Guide should remember this:

Do not stop the sentence to teach the word.

Read it smoothly. Point as you go. Repeat often.

That is the beginner method.

The Formula

If you want to reduce all of this into one easy formula:

Guide formula

Point. Read. Turn page. Repeat.

That is the system at the beginning.

A Simple Guide

For a brand-new Guide, this is the short version:

Do:

- read the words out loud
- point to each word as you say it
- keep the sentence smooth
- reread the same book often
- let the child join in naturally

Don't:

- teach letter sounds first
- make the child sound words out
- quiz constantly
- correct harshly
- rush to the next book

Remember:

The child first learns:

“That word says Sam.”

Decoding comes later.

Point.

Read.

Turn the page.

Repeat.